

MADHULIKA ITHA

Security Researcher | Usable Security | Human-Centered Security | Human-AI Systems
Baton Rouge, LA | +1 678-446-5039 | Madhulika.itha@gmail.com | [LinkedIn](#) | [GitHub](#)

PROFILE

PhD researcher in Computer Science working at the intersection of usable security, human behavior, and emerging technology. Experience spans security research, mixed-methods and qualitative research, product strategy, user research, and early-stage technology development. Interested in understanding how people interpret, navigate, and recover from security risks - and translating those findings into safer security and AI systems.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Computer Science | Louisiana State University May 2024 - Expected Dec 2029
Baton Rouge, LA
Graduate Research Assistant | Advisor: Phani Vadrevu, Ph.D., Assistant Professor | Research: Usable Security, Psychological Security, Human-Centered Security, Human-AI Systems
B.S. in Cognitive Science | The University of Texas at Dallas May 2023
Richardson, TX

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant | Louisiana State University Aug 2023 - Present
- Investigate security and privacy problems at the intersection of human behavior, system assumptions, access, authentication, recovery, and changing user circumstances.
- Design human-subject security research using qualitative and mixed-methods approaches, including interview protocols, screening criteria, recruitment strategies, consent procedures, and research instruments.
- Conduct literature synthesis and qualitative analysis to identify how users understand security mechanisms and where technical systems fail to account for lived experience.
- Translate behavioral findings into security implications, system requirements, and design recommendations; develop IRB protocols and privacy-preserving data-management workflows for sensitive research.
Security & Social Engineering Research | Louisiana State University 2024 - 2025
- Contributed to a mixed-methods study of personal impersonation attacks targeting digital payments on social media, examining how attackers exploit interpersonal trust to redirect payments.
- Participated in qualitative coding and inter-rater reliability procedures, and contributed to analysis of attacker behavior, evasion strategies, victim targeting, and platform-level security implications.
- Co-authored the resulting paper published at the 34th USENIX Security Symposium (USENIX Security 25).

SELECTED PUBLICATION

Nguyen, H. D., Dhungana, S., Itha, M., & Vadrevu, P. "Please don't send that bot anything": A Mixed-methods Study of Personal Impersonation Attacks Targeting Digital Payments on Social Media. *34th USENIX Security Symposium (USENIX Security 25)*, 2025, pp. 4859-4878. [USENIX](#)

PROFESSIONAL & ENTREPRENEURIAL EXPERIENCE

Product Strategist | Find Em All Jun 2025 - Jul 2026
- Helped shape product strategy for an early-stage platform combining social discovery and marketplace functionality around collectible interests.
- Worked with company leadership on target customers, product direction, market needs, competitive research, product requirements, roadmaps, onboarding, user journeys, and feature prioritization.
- Translated strategy into priorities across product, design, and development teams; incorporated security, privacy, access, and trust considerations into early-stage product decisions.

Dallas, TX

- Led a three-person front-end team developing an education technology platform designed to provide universities and education organizations with a more intuitive learning-management experience.
- Directed interface design and front-end execution, coordinated responsibilities, conducted design and quality checks, and maintained consistency across product experiences.
- Applied user research, personas, and journey mapping to guide product decisions; coordinated with back-end developers to align interface design with system functionality.

Co-Founder & Chief Executive Officer | Unheard Stories

Aug 2019 - Mar 2020

- Co-founded an anonymous online community for people to share difficult experiences and personal concerns while maintaining anonymity; grew the community to 100+ members.
- Led a 10-person team across community operations, outreach, social media, and the website, and established community structures and moderation practices for respectful participation.
- Advanced to the semifinals of the Blackstone LaunchPad startup competition while navigating early-stage funding, outreach, and user-growth constraints.

SELECTED SECURITY & PRODUCT PROJECTS**Second Thought - Intentional AI Interaction | Independent Portfolio Project**

2026

- Designed a browser-based concept for more intentional AI interaction, including configurable response-depth controls, reflection interventions, learning-oriented behaviors, and presentation assistance.
- Explored when an AI system should intervene versus remain passive, balancing user autonomy, cognitive effort, usability, interruption cost, and local-first privacy considerations.

Security Foundations for an Early-Stage Platform | Independent Portfolio Case Study

2026

- Mapped users, system components, data flows, trust boundaries, and security-sensitive actions; analyzed identity, authentication, authorization, account recovery, financial actions, permissions, and platform roles.
- Translated identified risks into prioritized security requirements and product recommendations designed for early-stage constraints without unnecessary user friction.

Task Redistribution System | Independent Portfolio Project

2026

- Designed a human-centered decision-support system for redistributing work when changing capacity, workload, or circumstances make an existing allocation unsustainable.
- Translated behavioral and organizational considerations into product requirements, workflows, and a research-informed interactive system concept.

CERTIFICATIONS

Google Cybersecurity Professional Certificate - Google / Coursera (Aug 2026): Nine-course program covering security risks and vulnerabilities, network security, Linux, SQL, Python, SIEM, IDS, incident response, and mitigation concepts.

Additional UX Training: UX Fundamentals: User Testing (Udemy, 2022); Figma UI/UX Design Essential Training (Udemy, 2022).

SKILLS

Security & Privacy: Usable Security, Human-Centered Security, Authentication & Account Recovery, Threat Modeling, Security Requirements, Risk Analysis, Social Engineering, Security & Privacy Research

Research: Qualitative Interviews, Mixed-Methods Research, Study Design, Thematic Analysis, Qualitative Coding, Inter-Rater Reliability, Literature Review, Human-Subjects Research, Survey Design, Research Ethics, IRB Protocol Development

Product & UX: Product Strategy, Product Requirements, User Research, Competitive Analysis, User Journeys, Personas, Product Roadmapping, Prioritization, Prototyping, Interaction Design, Figma

Technical: Python, JavaScript, HTML/CSS, C++, SQL, Linux, Selenium, Git/GitHub, Node.js, MongoDB, Docker, Qualtrics, LaTeX, VS Code